8.10 Paris Agreement and Bolsonaro

Jair Bolsonaro, like Donald Trump, emerged as a vocal populist opponent of the Paris Agreement, expressing outright disdain for its emissions-reduction targets and the accountability mechanisms it imposed. Brazil's commitment under the Agreement included an ambitious goal to reduce carbon emissions by 43 percent by 2030 from 2005 levels, with a particular emphasis on curbing deforestation in the Amazon. Such an aggressive target reflected Brazil's long-standing position as a global leader on climate change. As the world's largest carbon sink, the Amazon plays a critical role in mitigating climate change and offsetting the negative effects of global warming, such as extreme weather patterns.[92]

However, Bolsonaro viewed these commitments through the lens of populist ideology, rejecting the Agreement as a symbol of elite interference and an affront to Brazil's sovereignty.[93] He argued that conservation efforts posed a threat to Brazil's economic development and control over its resources, fueling his broader narrative of resistance to external constraints. Bolsonaro's administration actively dismantled environmental protections, cutting funding for ecological programs and removing scientists who reported on the alarming rate of Amazonian deforestation. Denying the very existence of climate change, Bolsonaro frequently attacked environmentalists, labeling them the "self-proclaimed climate elite" and amplifying his administration's alignment with agribusiness interests, which stood to benefit from deforestation (Mendes Motta and Hauber 2023).

Bolsonaro's hostility extended to the Paris Agreement itself, which he initially threatened to abandon. While he later agreed to remain in the pact, partially as a result of widespread public support for it within Brazil, his cooperation came with significant caveats. He demanded assurances that Brazil would retain sovereignty over its natural resources, including the Amazon rainforest, and called for financial compensation in exchange for curbing emissions. Bolsonaro's rhetoric was unequivocal: Brazil would not cede control of its land to "native tribes or international jurisdiction," and any preservation efforts would have to be economically beneficial for Brazil.[94]

In response, members of the Paris Agreement employed a range of strategies to manage Bolsonaro's defiance. The EU sought to appease him